TECHNOVA

Grievance_and_Escalation_Procedure 2026

Effective Date: June 15, 2026
Version: 2.0
Approved By: Chief Human Resources Officer (CHRO).

1.0 Our Commitment to a Fair Workplace

1.1 Purpose and Philosophy

At Technova, we are dedicated to fostering a positive, respectful, and productive work environment where every employee feels valued and heard. This Grievance and Escalation Procedure is designed to provide a clear, fair, and consistent framework for raising and resolving workplace concerns.

Our philosophy is that open communication and early resolution are the most effective ways to address issues. We believe that by providing a structured and transparent process, we can address conflicts constructively, reinforce our company values, and ensure that all employees are treated with dignity and respect. This procedure serves as a core tool to help us uphold our commitment to a healthy workplace culture.

1.2 Scope of This Policy

This policy applies to all regular full-time and part-time employees of Technova. It covers any concern, problem, or complaint that an employee may have regarding their work, the work environment, or their employment relationship. This includes, but is not limited to, issues related to working conditions, treatment by managers or colleagues, and the application of company policies.

1.3 Core Principles

This procedure is founded on four essential principles that guide our approach at every stage:

- **Confidentiality:** All grievances will be handled with the utmost discretion. Information will only be shared with those who have a legitimate need to know in order to investigate and resolve the concern.
- **Non-Retaliation:** Technova has a strict zero-tolerance policy for retaliation. No employee will face adverse action, harassment, or discrimination for raising a grievance in good faith or for participating in an investigation. Any act of retaliation is a serious violation of company policy and will result in disciplinary action, up to and including termination.
- **Impartiality and Fairness:** Every grievance will be investigated and reviewed objectively and impartially. Decisions will be based on a thorough and fair assessment of the facts. All parties involved will have an opportunity to present their side of the story.
- **Timeliness:** We are committed to addressing all concerns promptly. This policy outlines specific timelines for each stage of the process to ensure that grievances are resolved without unnecessary delay.

1.4 What is a Grievance?

A grievance is a formal complaint raised by an employee concerning a work-related issue that they believe is unfair, unjust, or in violation of company policy or legal standards. Examples of issues that may form the basis of a grievance include:

- Perceived unfair or inequitable treatment.
- Bullying, harassment, or discrimination.
- Concerns about health and safety in the workplace.
- Disputes over the interpretation or application of HR policies like leave and work hours.
- Violations of the company's Code of Conduct.

1.5 What is Not Covered by This Procedure?

This procedure is not intended to address every type of workplace disagreement. The following issues are typically handled through separate, specific processes:

- **Disciplinary Action:** Appeals against formal disciplinary warnings or actions.
- **Termination of Employment:** Decisions related to the formal termination of employment.
- **Compensation Decisions:** Issues related to salary, bonus amounts, or equity awards, which are managed through the annual compensation review process.
- **Performance Feedback:** Disagreements with performance ratings or feedback received during a performance review.
- **Whistleblowing:** Reports of illegal activity, financial malpractice, or serious dangers to public health, which should be raised under the company's Whistleblower Policy.

2.0 Roles and Responsibilities

A successful grievance process relies on the active and responsible participation of all parties involved.

2.1 The Employee

- To attempt, where appropriate, to resolve concerns informally at the earliest opportunity.
- To raise formal grievances in a timely and factual manner, providing all relevant information.
- To cooperate fully with any investigation.
- To maintain strict confidentiality throughout the entire process.

2.2 The Manager

- To foster an environment where employees feel comfortable raising concerns.
- To listen actively and take all coworker concerns seriously.
- To make genuine efforts to resolve issues informally and promptly.
- To participate constructively in formal investigations when required.
- To uphold the core principles of confidentiality and non-retaliation.

2.3 The Human Resources (HR) Department

- To act as an impartial steward of the grievance procedure.
- To provide advice and support to both employees and managers throughout the process.
- To ensure all formal grievances are properly documented, investigated, and resolved in accordance with this policy.
- To appoint trained and completely impartial investigators.
- To maintain secure records of all grievance proceedings.

2.4 The Grievance Committee

A formal Grievance Committee may be convened to hear appeals. The Committee typically consists of a senior HR leader, a senior leader from a neutral department, and another impartial manager. The Committee's role is to provide a final, objective review of the grievance and the initial decision.

3.0 Informal Grievance Resolution

3.1 The Value of Informal Resolution

We strongly encourage employees to try and resolve concerns informally before initiating a formal grievance. Many workplace issues arise from simple misunderstandings or miscommunications and can often be resolved quickly and effectively through direct conversation. An informal approach can help preserve working relationships and find mutually agreeable solutions without the need for a lengthy formal process.

3.2 Step-by-Step Informal Process

- **Reflect and Prepare:** Before approaching anyone, take a moment to clearly identify the issue. What specifically is the problem, and what is your desired outcome?
- **Speak with Your Manager:** Your direct manager is usually the best first point of contact. Schedule a private meeting to discuss your concerns openly and professionally.
- **Alternative Contact:** If you are not comfortable speaking with your manager, or if your concern is about your manager, you can approach their manager or an HR Business Partner for an informal discussion.
- **Discussion and Agreement:** The goal of the informal discussion is to reach a shared understanding and agree on a path forward, which could involve clarifying expectations, changing a process, or simply having a constructive dialogue.

3.3 The Role of Mediation

In some cases, a facilitated conversation with a neutral third party can be helpful. HR can act as an impartial mediator to help employees and managers discuss their issues and find common ground. Mediation is a voluntary process aimed at achieving a mutually acceptable resolution.

3.4 Informal Resolution Case Study: Recognizing Contributions

- **Scenario:** Alex, a graphic designer, feels that his colleague, Ben, is consistently taking credit for his ideas in team meetings, which is causing friction and demotivating Alex.

- **Action:** Instead of immediately filing a complaint, Alex schedules a one-on-one meeting with his manager, Sarah. He calmly explains the situation with specific examples and states that his desired outcome is fair recognition. Sarah listens, validates his feelings, and agrees to observe team dynamics. She also has a separate coaching conversation with Ben about teamwork and acknowledging contributors.
- **Outcome:** In subsequent meetings, Sarah asks for input from all team members, and Ben becomes more mindful of giving credit. Alex feels heard and respected, and the issue is resolved without damaging the working relationship.

4.0 Formal Grievance Procedure

4.1 When to Initiate a Formal Grievance

A formal grievance should be initiated when an attempt at informal resolution has been unsuccessful, the nature of the grievance is too serious for an informal approach, or the grievance is against your direct manager and you are not comfortable addressing it with them informally.

4.2 Step-by-Step Formal Process

- **Step 1: Filing a Formal Grievance:** To begin the formal process, the employee must submit a written grievance to the HR department using the official Grievance Form. The submission should include a detailed description of the event, relevant dates, locations, witnesses, supporting evidence, and your desired outcome.
- **Step 2: Acknowledgment and Assessment:** HR will acknowledge receipt of the formal grievance in writing within two (2) working days. HR will then conduct an initial assessment and appoint an impartial investigator.
- **Step 3: Formal Investigation:** The investigator will conduct a thorough and objective investigation, interviewing the grievant, the respondent, and relevant witnesses, while reviewing documents like emails and company records privately.
- **Step 4: Grievance Meeting:** After the investigation is complete, a formal grievance meeting will be scheduled and chaired by an uninvolved manager. The employee has the right to be accompanied at this meeting by a work colleague or a certified trade union representative.
- **Step 5: Decision and Notification:** Following the meeting, the chairperson will consider all the evidence and communicate the final decision and corrective remedies in writing, typically within five (5) working days.

4.3 Target Timelines for the Formal Process

- **Acknowledgment of Grievance:** 2 working days.
- **Completion of Investigation:** 15 working days.
- **Grievance Meeting:** Within 5 working days of investigation completion.
- **Written Decision:** Within 5 working days of the meeting.

4.4 Formal Process Case Study: Promotion Discrepancies

- **Scenario:** Maria, an employee in the finance department, believes she was overlooked for a promotion in favor of a less-qualified colleague, feeling it is a case of bias. She loses trust in her manager and files a formal grievance.
- **Action:** Maria completes the Grievance Form, citing specific projects and performance metrics. HR acknowledges it within two days and assigns a senior HR specialist to investigate. The investigator interviews Maria, her manager, and the promoted colleague, and reviews interview notes and promotion criteria. A meeting is held, chaired by the Director of Finance, which Maria attends with a colleague for support.
- **Outcome:** The investigation concludes that the selection process lacked clear, objective scoring, leading to the appearance of bias. The Director upholds part of the grievance, committing to a detailed development plan for Maria and a mandate for the department to implement a more structured promotion process.

5.0 Escalation and Appeal Process

5.1 The Right to Appeal

If an employee is not satisfied with the outcome of the formal grievance procedure, they have the right to appeal the decision. An appeal is not a re-investigation of the grievance but a review of the original decision and the process used to reach it.

5.2 Grounds for an Appeal

An appeal may be submitted on one or more of the following grounds:

- New evidence has come to light that was not available during the original investigation.
- There was a significant flaw in the procedure followed, which may have affected the outcome.
- The decision or the resulting action was not reasonable or proportionate based on the findings.

5.3 How to Submit an Appeal

An employee wishing to appeal must do so in writing to the HR department within five (5) working days of receiving the formal grievance decision. The written appeal must clearly state the specific grounds on which the appeal is being made.

5.4 The Appeal Hearing and Final Decision

The appeal will be heard by an Appeal Panel consisting of a senior leader not previously involved and the Grievance Committee. The employee will be invited to present their case and retains the right to be accompanied by a colleague or union representative.

The decision of the Appeal Panel is final, and there is no further internal right of appeal. The final decision will be communicated to the employee in writing within five (5) working days of the appeal hearing.

5.5 Appeal Process Case Study: Strengthening Remedies

- **Scenario:** In the case above, Maria is not satisfied with the remedy offered, feeling a development plan alone does not address the core issue of bias in the promotion decision.

- **Action:** Maria submits a written appeal within five days. An Appeal Panel is convened, chaired by the company's Chief Human Resources Officer (CHRO). At the appeal hearing, Maria argues her case.
- **Outcome:** The Appeal Panel reviews the case and agrees that the remedy should be strengthened. The panel's final decision includes a formal written apology and mandates that Maria be automatically included in the interview pool for the next relevant promotion opportunity. This decision is final.

6.0 Handling Specific Types of Grievances

6.1 Grievances Involving a Direct Manager

If a grievance is about an employee's direct manager, the employee is not required to address it with them informally. The formal grievance should be submitted directly to the next level of management or to an HR Business Partner.

6.2 Harassment, Bullying, or Discrimination

Allegations of harassment, bullying, or discrimination are taken extremely seriously. These grievances will always be handled through the formal procedure and will be investigated by specially trained HR professionals or external investigators. These investigations are governed by the company's separate Anti-Harassment and Equal Employment Opportunity policies.

6.3 Collective Grievances vs. Whistleblowing

- **Collective Grievances:** If a group of employees shares the same grievance, they may submit it collectively. One or two employees should be nominated as spokespersons for the group to liaise with HR throughout the process.
- **Whistleblowing Distinction:** A grievance typically relates to an employee's personal circumstances or treatment. A whistleblowing complaint involves reporting information that is in the public interest, such as criminal activity, corruption, or serious dangers, which should be raised under the company's separate Whistleblower Policy.

7.0 Confidentiality and Data Protection

7.1 Maintaining Confidentiality

All individuals involved in a grievance procedure—the grievant, the respondent, witnesses, managers, and HR—are required to maintain strict confidentiality. Breaches of confidentiality can undermine the integrity of the process and may result in disciplinary action.

7.2 Data Protection and Record-Keeping

HR will create and maintain a confidential case file for each formal grievance. This file will be stored securely and separately from the employee's main personnel file. Access will be restricted strictly to authorized HR and legal personnel, and all records will be managed in compliance with data protection laws.

8.0 Policy Review and Training

8.1 Policy Review Framework

This policy will be reviewed by the HR department every two years, or more frequently if required by changes in legislation, to ensure it remains effective and fully compliant.

8.2 Training and Awareness

All managers will receive mandatory training on this policy and on their role in handling workplace concerns effectively and empathetically. The policy will be made available to all employees via the company's intranet, and it will be covered thoroughly during new hire orientation.

9.0 Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1: Do I have to talk to my manager before filing a formal grievance? A: While we strongly encourage informal resolution first, you are not required to speak with your manager if you are uncomfortable doing so or if your grievance is about them. In that case, you can go directly to HR.

Q2: Will filing a grievance negatively impact my career? A: Absolutely not. Our non-retaliation policy is strictly enforced. It is a serious violation of company policy to penalize an employee in any way for raising a concern in good faith.

Q3: Can I remain anonymous when I file a grievance? A: Due to the need to conduct a thorough investigation, it is generally not possible to remain completely anonymous when filing a formal grievance. However, we will maintain confidentiality to the greatest extent possible.

Q4: How long does the formal grievance process take? A: We aim to complete the entire formal process, from filing to decision, within approximately 25-30 working days. However, complex cases may take longer.

Q5: Who can I bring with me to a grievance or appeal meeting? A: You have the right to be accompanied by a single individual who is a current work colleague or a certified trade union representative. They are there for support and are not permitted to answer questions on your behalf.

Q6: What happens if my grievance is not upheld? A: If your grievance is not upheld, HR will still offer support and may suggest mediation or other actions to help repair working relationships and move forward constructively.

Q7: Can I withdraw my grievance after I have filed it? A: Yes, you can withdraw your grievance at any stage by notifying HR in writing. However, in cases involving serious allegations, the company may be obligated to continue the investigation regardless.

10.0 Formal Grievance Form Framework

The official, downloadable Formal Grievance Form is securely hosted on our internal HR portal. For reference, the structured data input fields required for filing include:

- **Employee Details:** Full Name, Employee ID, Department, Direct Manager's Name, and Date of Submission.
- **Section 1: Details of the Grievance:** A detailed description of the grievance including specific facts, dates, times, locations, individuals involved, and names of any witnesses.
- **Section 2: Informal Resolution Attempts:** A descriptive summary of any steps already taken to resolve the matter informally.
- **Section 3: Desired Resolution:** A clear description of the specific outcome you are seeking to resolve the workplace concern.

- **Section 4: Supporting Documentation:** A list of all physical or digital documents (e.g., emails, files, messages) provided to support the filing.
- **Sign-off Block:** Employee physical or electronic signature and date lines.

11.0 Revision History

- **Version:** 2.0
- **Date of Revision:** June 15, 2026
- **Summary of Changes:** Updated comprehensive Grievance and Escalation procedures and unified tracking matrices for the 2026 calendar year cycle.
- **Approved By:** Chief Human Resources Officer (CHRO).